

After graduation, Jackson accepted a teaching position as a junior high math teacher in a small Christian school. Sticking to his resolve to remain unmarried, he seemed oblivious to the attempts by others on the school staff and in his church to match him up with the right young woman. He was content as he was.

During the summer after his second year of teaching, the school hired a new teacher to take the split fifth/sixth grade class. It was Linn. She and Jackson quickly got acquainted, and, while it wasn't exactly love at first sight, Jackson suspected his self-imposed bachelor days were coming to an end. He and Linn were married in a simple ceremony during spring break that year, with their school community, church friends, and parents in attendance. They decided to hold off having children indefinitely. Jackson was still a little skittish about bringing a child into the world, and Linn wanted to have several terms of teaching under her belt before taking a few years off to be home with children. Besides, they wanted to have a nest egg of savings on hand.

But, as everyone eventually learns, life rarely follows a predictable course. When they had been married just two years, they learned that Linn was pregnant.

Despite his misgivings, Jackson found himself excited. He and Linn were in a committed, Christ-centered marriage, and he knew they would break his family's tendency toward broken relationships. And Linn had always planned on being a mother, so she was also pleased, though a little worried at the prospect of their losing her financial contribution. The school they worked for paid low salaries, and they had been unable to accumulate any significant savings. But they were able to live frugally, and they did have what seemed to be an adequate insurance plan, so they thought they would be all right financially. The baby would be born during their summer break, so Linn would be able to work right up to the time of the birth. They decided to forgo an ultrasound that would tell them what the baby's gender was, preferring to be surprised. The pregnancy was going so smoothly that they thought maybe they'd have their second child sooner than later.